



THROWING IT DOWN
Students fight social issues through art
News pg. 2

WOMEN'S RIGHTS
SCOTUS hears case to revoke rights
Opinions pg. 3

REMATCH
Bears prepare to take on Vikings
Sports pg. 5

Stress, burnout strains education system nationally, locally

District, school fight to avert crisis as nationwide teacher shortage increases

Justin Diep
Co-Editor in Chief

There are fewer people choosing teaching as a career and there are more educators leaving the field. Effects of the higher workload for those remaining are becoming apparent and causing burnout. It's a nation-wide problem that has been brought to the forefront since the pandemic started.

According to a study done by MissionSquare Institute, 52% of kindergarten through 12th grade employees feel stressed or burned out.

Many teachers at Bryan High are also feeling the burn out. In a survey given to all Bryan High staff, 50 responded, of which 42 were teachers. This represents 23% of the 215 person staff. The survey found 76% of respondents reported feeling stressed or burned out.

The Nebraska State Education Association (NSEA) identified both recruitment and retention problems of educators in a survey sent out to its members last month. Educators reported more stress and less time to plan than in previous years. Additionally, the Nebraska college system reported a 50% drop in enrollment in the education field over the last decade.

"The social, emotional and academic toll of the COVID-19 pandemic is growing worse by the day,"

NSEA President Jenni Benson said. "Staff shortages and quarantines have stretched teachers thin to the breaking point. In addition to their own classes, teachers are covering classes for teachers who are ill or quarantining. They are losing their plan time, their time for one-on-one instruction with students, time to collaborate with their colleagues, and time to talk with parents. And this is the second year of these challenges – everything is compounded."

NSEA is currently calling on state lawmakers to increase salaries for public education employees and is requesting to use \$50 million of the state's COVID relief funds for a \$1000 stipend for their extra work.

Omaha Public Schools' human resources team reported last month the district is currently about 93% staffed with most of the vacancies being in support staff roles such as paras and nutrition service workers.

"Staff shortages in education is a decades-long challenge that has more recently come to our area, heightened by the pandemic like every industry," OPS spokeswoman Bridget Blevins said. "Omaha Public Schools has taken numerous steps to thoughtfully address these challenges in a variety of ways."

Some steps OPS has taken are modifying the

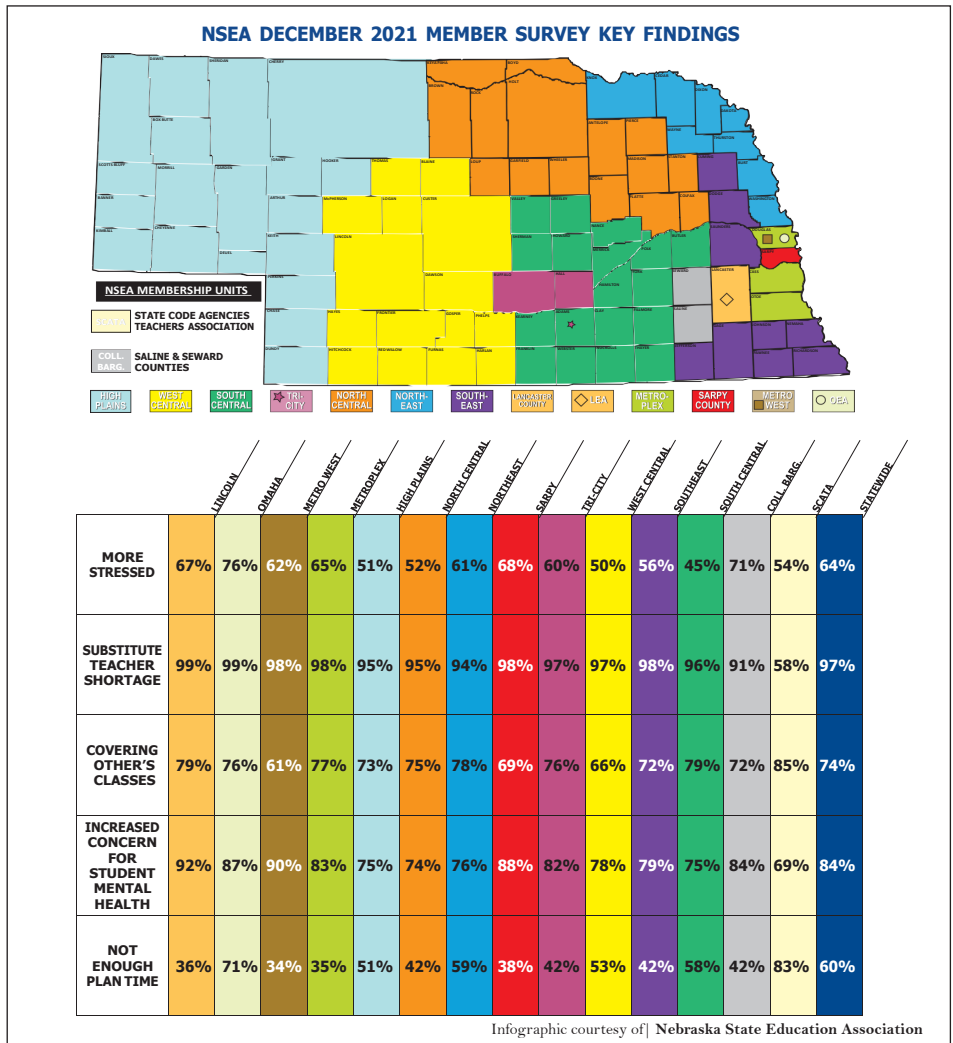
calendar to allow for more teacher workdays and hiring students in support roles such as interpreters and summer interns at elementary schools. Additionally, they recently launched a concierge program that would assist in non-instructional roles such as assisting cafeteria and transportation staff. Long term, OPS is investing in its para to teacher pipeline and its teaching academies that will be implemented at all its high schools.

However, Bryan High is almost fully staffed with only two vacant teaching positions, one in the English department and one in JROTC. Both positions are filled by long term subs.

"Our goal is to have a highly qualified and certified teacher in every classroom at," Bryan principal Rony Ortega said. "When this hasn't been possible, we have secured long term substitutes who have a strong background in education and know our Bryan High community."

According to a study by RAND Corporation, since March 2020, over half of respondents cited the pandemic and stress from it as their main reason for leaving the profession. The second reason was lack of pay. In an anonymous survey conducted of Bryan High staff members, the stressors indicated by RAND Corporation are on their minds too.

"It's [The Pandemic] been pretty awful, but it's



shown a lot of people that you need to be happy in life and not just work for the sake of work, there are other options out there," a Bryan teacher who wished to remain anonymous said.

They also agree that teacher pay is too low. 88% of the Bryan High staff who responded to the survey reported they felt underpaid for the work they do.

"Teachers don't become

educators for the money, but we'd like to be compensated for the actual work we do," one Bryan teacher said. "We don't just teach a subject. We become parents, counselors, aides, we embody a whole system of support that takes a toll on us individually."

Others have said additional responsibilities outside the scope of their contract are contributing to

their stress. "It feels like society is dumping large scale social failures onto the backs of teachers and then expecting us to make up for those larger failures," a Bryan teacher said. "As teachers are expected to do more with less, we will leave the profession."

While national studies have shown the crisis in

SEE TEACHERS | **PAGE 2**

Junior class officers announced, prom 2022 planning commences



President
Bryan Benitez



Vice President
Wendy Pacheco-Menivar



Secretary
Bryan Diaz-Quezada



Treasurer
Justin Diep

Daisy Chinchilla Ramos
Reporter

Elections for the Class of 2023 Junior Class Officers (JCO) were held last week and the results are in. Joining 18 of their peers who will be JCO ambassadors are President Bryan Benitez, Vice President Wendy Pacheco-Menivar, Secretary Bryan Diaz-Quezada and Treasurer Justin Diep.

The group of juniors

will work to promote school and class pride and help with ACT preparations, but their largest task will be putting on prom.

"I hope to have an amazing prom that rivals previous proms," Benitez said.

While this is a large task, much of the decision making has already been done for prom. It will be on April 30, at the Durham Museum. They do not have a name for it yet, but plan

on having a vintage Hollywood feel to the event.

"The Durham is the perfect venue," JCO sponsor Ranae Duncan said. "It's elegant and has an art deco design to it already that will fit the glamorous, vintage Hollywood feel."

While last year's prom was funded by an anonymous philanthropist, this year's is not. Students will have to pay for their tickets once again. They will be \$25 each or \$45 for

a couple, which is the same price tickets were pre-pandemic. They will go on sale the week of prom.

"I wish it could be free to attend, but that's not how it goes," Duncan said. "The funds for this year's prom came from ticket sales from the 2019 prom and the revenue from this year's prom will pay for next year's."

As far as details go for the 2022 prom, the colors will be red, black, white

and gold; the DJ will be DJ Devon Dupree who has been the DJ in the past and there will be a photo booth and snacks.

In addition to prom, they will be in charge of a prom spirit week to build excitement for the big event.

"Spirit weeks kind of bring the classes together and build school spirit and that's what we're supposed to do as junior class officers," Diep said.